Making the Case for Studio Furniture

BY JOHN LAVINE



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The Furniture Society has been in existence now for over six years; it was established in 1996 with the intention to "advance the art of furnituremaking, by inspiring creativity, promoting excellence, and fostering understanding of this art and its place in society." This is a big agenda, and to that end, there have been six national conferences, dozens of exhibitions, and various publications, including a quarterly newsletter and two books. The focus of this article is several of the more "public" events of the last year: a book, a major exhibition of contemporary case furniture that was shown at the Elvehjem Museum at the University of Wisconsin in Madison in conjunction with this past summer's conference, and the catalog accompanying that show. Most of the images on these pages are from the exhibition.

The first book of the Furniture Society—*Furniture Studio: The Heart of the Functional Arts* (published in 1999 and discussed in the December 2000 issue of *Woodwork*)—included historical essays, critiques, memoirs, reviews, some "how-to," a photo gallery, and more—a big mix, of uneven quality, that suffered somewhat from taking on too much, but was nonetheless an important and exciting first step. The second volume in this ongoing *Furniture Studio* series, *Tradition in Contemporary Furniture*, is much more focussed, but still tries to cover a lot of ground. The book contains eight essays, punctuated by two photo galleries, which, to use Ed Cooke's phrase from his introductory essay in the first book, offer various approaches to "building a common history and language." As essayist Mark Kingwell puts it, "Somewhere between *House Beautiful* and Plato's austere *Republic* lies the unexplored territory of a true philosophy of furniture."

Loy Martin's "Decoding Studio Furniture" serves as an introduction to the second book, and the notion he puts forward is that "the fundamental reality of furnituremaking is work itself." He begins by examining a blanket chest by Mark Del Guidice. There is surface decoration on its end panels that appears to be abstracted vertical lines but is in fact a repeating message in Morse Code: "…labor of love of labor of love…" Martin suggests that this kind of encrypted message might be

specific to the nature of studio furniture and a key to its understanding. He also points to Brad Engstrom's "10,000 Dreams," a wonderfully over-the-top piece that gains power from its obsession with its own creation. Engstrom's piece references the tradition of tramp art, typically done by vagabonds, itinerant workers, and others who—like students—work outside the structures of shop labor. As Martin notes, "the traditional artist's studio [also] stands outside this tradition [the making of useful objects in small shop production] and goes on to say that "we should probably recognize the widespread attempt to redefine studio furniture as fine art as a kind of 'class shift.'" In high contrast to Engstrom's piece is the work of Kristina Madsen, who uses a chip-carving technique to very different effect, creating objects of serene beauty that require every bit as much labor but have neither interest in nor need to "discuss" the fact.

Martin's general point—that studio furniture can often "be read"—certainly offers a viable tool, but his focus on making can be more or less useful, depending on the object in question, and I think that his discussion of Garry Bennett's "Nail Cabinet" reveals a significant limitation to that focus. After a lengthy interpretation of the infamous nail's role as a signifier of a certain type of rough construction in opposition to the labor-intensive finger joints that are purposely displayed, he concludes by saying that the piece is ultimately "about work, about the time and skill it takes to make a basic cabinet in a furniture workshop and about Bennett's ambivalence toward that tradition of work." To the contrary, Bennett can be pretty unambiguous; he has elsewhere stated about his process of work: "There's no labor of love here 'cause I don't love labor." What Martin's reading doesn't allow for, based as it is within the terms of a craft sensibility, is a means to address the possibility that the cabinet might be a provocation to think beyond such self-referential issues as the work involved in its making. Indeed, in a way that no amount of surface ornamentation (which, for all its "artfulness," is still very much a part of the craft tradition) could ever succeed in doing, Bennett's piece created a new conversation in the furniture community, and expanded the terms of discussion and debate to include issues perhaps more pertinent to the world of art. It pushed the craft world far outside its comfort zone.

Comfort—more specifically, the reassurance of the familiar—is a key dynamic in Miguel Gomez-Ibañez's essay "Understanding Tradition," in which he





OPPOSITE PAGE—
Bob Trotman, "White Guy" (1994); Limewood, drawer mechanisms, paint; 64" x 36" x 27".

THIS PAGE—
Kristina Madsen, "Cabinet on Stand" (1998); Bubinga, dyed pearwood, ebony; 48" x 32" x 14".

Brad Engstrom, "10,000 Dreams" (1999); Basswood, pastels; 54" x 25" x 12".



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"Boston Court Cupboard" (c. 1670-80); Oak, pine, maple, cedar, walnut.

"Massachusetts High Chest" (c. 1695-1720); Walnut, walnut burl veneer, pine.

Tommy Simpson, "Firsts" (1988); Painted poplar, zinc sheets; 59" x 38" x 18".

Silas Kopf, "Typewriter Desk" (1987); Mahogany, satinwood, marquetry woods; 46" x 51" x 22".

argues that, contrary to the view that traditional and contemporary makers stand in opposition to each other, both are actually part of a continuum of making that is always borrowing from, adapting, or referencing the past in each new style.

This affinity was clear in some of the pieces assembled for "Contemporary Studio Case Furniture," the show at the Elvehjem Museum. Kristina Madsen uses a neo-classical form for her "Cabinet on Stand." Silas Kopf gives a contemporary twist to the traditional practice of trompe l'oeil marquetry in his "Typewriter Desk." Even someone like Tommy Simpson, who uses historical references in a more post-modern way, is creating a work of reassurance and comfort in "Firsts." To make the points of comparison and contrast even more evident, seventeen pieces of early American furniture (two of which are pictured above) from the Chipstone Foundation were displayed on the mezzanine across from the case furniture show.

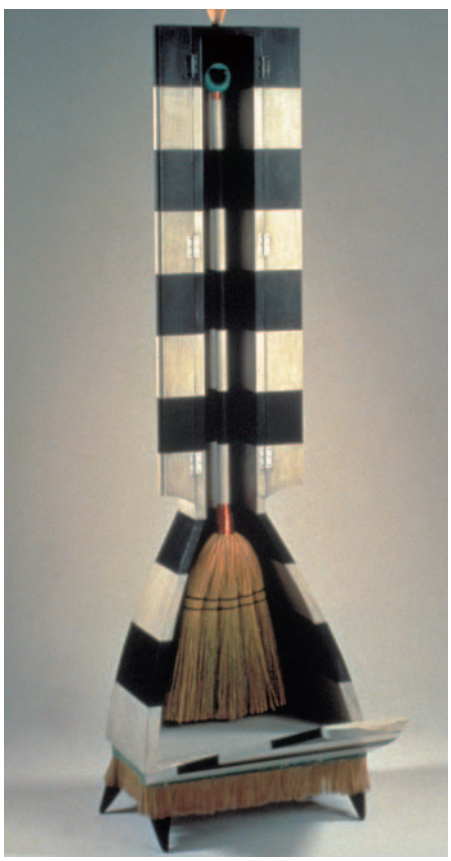
Significantly, this "conversation with the past" is not only one of maker-to-maker; it is a matter of social and cultural discourse. The social context for discussing furniture is carried through a number of the book's essays, and is perhaps most succinctly and eloquently stated by Jon Binzen, who writes in "Fitting In": "Furniture making is a social art. A dialogue in physical form between maker and user; between use and grace. And in this respect, furniture is unchanging. The demands of function draw a direct line between the furniture makers of classical antiquity and those working today. Now as then, the furniture maker's challenge is to give elegant expression to human need. Furniture consecrates use."

There is more to his quote, and I will return to that later, but I would like to dwell for a moment on this matter of use, especially in connection with exhibitions of furniture. Tom Loeser, one of the cocurators of the show, is keenly aware of the difficulty when he writes in his catalog essay: "In the end, function is still the crucial identifying marker that distinguishes the pieces in this show from work that is pure sculpture. One result of the functional aspect is that furniture objects not only have a viewer, but also a user. There is a bit of a dilemma in mounting an exhibition of case pieces in a museum setting: Case furniture contains an inside story, an interior space that must be physically accessed by drawer, door, or lid. That space is crucial to the meaning of the piece, yet the 'hands-off' museum environment prohibits that exploration."

The levels of this compromise are various and multiple. As Loeser also points out, experiencing furniture engages all the senses, and this interaction both animates the piece and stimulates our thoughts and feelings about it. For example, Jere Osgood's "Summer 99 Shell Desk" was displayed with the cover up, revealing the interior, but stripping the piece of one of its carefully-designed visages. As another example, Brian Wilson's "Keeper of Memories" is a striking image in a museum setting, but I personally would find the piece an even more arresting and haunting presence if I encountered it in a house, perhaps in a bedroom serving as a valet, with a shirt held in its outstretched hand. Wilson has already filled and sealed the drawers with stuff,









Jere Osgood, "Summer 99 Shell Desk" [two views] (1999); Bubinga, wenge, Ceylonese satinwood, leather, brass; 44" x 43" x 33".

Andy Buck, "Broom Cabinet" (1992); Ash, milk paint, copper, bristle; 73" x 19" x 12".

Brian Wilson, "Keeper of Memories" (1994); Polychromed basswood, steel, leather, found

"the detritus of everyday life," almost in anticipation of a museum setting, but I strongly suspect that in actual use those drawers would fill in an equally (maybe even more) effective way.

This tension of use/non-use takes a different form in Andy Buck's "Broom Cabinet," which poses questions about everyday objects and our rather unconscious use of them. We can easily imagine using a broom, but the maker has rendered *this one* an object of contemplation, wrapped up in its own display case or presentation box. It makes us stop and think, but only once, and I would contend that this elevated museum "status" trades away the potency that does reside in performing the actual ritual of opening the cabinet and removing—and using—the broom. That interaction has been rendered a theoretical construct.

There is an undeniable materiality at the core of the relationship between furniture and the human condition, but there is more to the discussion than simply talking about use. "How the mundane and the profound are related" is an interplay of function, aesthetics, and concepts, and Mark Kingwell delineates these wonderfully in his essay "More Beauty and More Deep Wonder." A professor of philosophy, Kingwell begins by introducing us to Plato's discussion of a bed. Simply put, in Plato's world there is the Idea of Bed, the physical bed, and the image or representation of a bed, in declining order of reality. Putting his hierarchy aside, this three-part nature of bed can be neatly symbolized in "shorthand" using the personages of philosopher, craftsperson, and artist. Each of these three personages is given voice, in varying degree from whole to none, in the creation of every piece of furniture.

Connected as it is to the human condition, furniture can express the whole cycle of birth, life, and death. Rosanne Somerson's "Father and Child Cabinet" and her earlier "Mother and Child Cabinet" (not part of the show) are straightforward in their contemplation of the family. Chris Vance's "Staircase" reveals itself more slowly. First it is, as it says, a staircase; referencing a step-tansu, it is also a set of drawers. Its full meaning, and poignancy, comes when we learn that it was conceived in part as a tribute to his mother who had recently died: the lamp at the top casts light as one finds his way up the stairs. Russell Baldon's "Time Capsule" is literally that, with assorted messages to the future secured inside the upper compartment. But the piece is the metaphoric body of the maker as well, a self-portrait of the artist as his (own) creation.

Later in his essay, Kingwell quotes Marshall McLuhan on the relationship between furniture and the human body: "A chair outers the human posterior. The squat position is 'translated' into a new

matter…But chair at once causes something else to happen…A table is born…But table also calls forth new arrangements of people at table. The fixing of a posture of the body in a chair initiates a whole series of consequences." We are back to the causality of functionalism, a whole world spun out of the imperative of use, but I am reminded of a story by the late novelist Italo Calvino, who fantasizes a very different cosmology. In his story "All at One Point," Calvino locates the act of creation in human desire. "It was enough for her to say, at a certain moment: 'Oh, if I only had some room, how I'd like to make some noodles for you boys!' And in that moment we all thought of the space her round arms would occupy, moving the rolling pin over the dough…we thought of the space the flour would occupy, and the wheat for the flour, and the fields to raise the wheat, and the mountain from which the water would flow to irrigate the fields…"—on and on, ever-expanding, until an entire universe is created out of that singular wish.

This impulse of generosity, and its precondition of modesty, is at the heart of the essay by Jon Binzen that I quoted from earlier. To continue his thought: "…In the last decades of the twentieth century, many makers of handmade furniture began to flout the demands of function and veer off in the direction of sculpture…This [furniture] can be exciting in a photo or in a gallery but frustrating as a dining table…By abandoning function, or downplaying it, metafurniture gains artistic freedom but loses its entrée into the heart of daily life."

The heart of daily life is exactly where Jeff Parsons and Bruce Beeken want their furniture to be, and Scott Landis' essay, "Furniture with a Sense of Place," tells the story of their effort to make and market furniture from sustainably-harvested "character wood" on a large scale…by studio furniture standards. As Landis says: "Beeken and Parsons converge on the design from within and without, focusing on their materials, the means of construction, and the context in which their work will live. …It's one thing to build an elegant chair for a wealthy client or even a set of six custom dining chairs. It's quite another to balance comfort, durability, and aesthetics against the economics of producing several hundred chairs for an institutional venue."

This furniture is not aimed for the gallery or museum, nor for the collector; it will not be seen in a show like the one at the Elvehjem Museum, nor is it likely to appear in the gallery section of the *Furniture Studio* books. It has a very different context and intent. In an interesting way, Beeken and Parsons can be seen as the modern-day successors to the Modernist movement's desire to create well-designed furniture for mass production using "appropriate technology."

The legacy of Modernism makes a number of appearances in the book, and it is worth noting the ways it is—and, curiously, is not—mentioned in several of the articles. It is first mentioned in Miguel Gomez-Ibañez's essay on tradition, in which it is taken to task for its unprecedented "break from all aspects of the past." But it *appears* most prominently in Kathran Siegel's article on "Art Furniture." Art furniture is described as "resting somewhere between two traditions: fine art and







Rosanne Somerson, "Father and Child Cabinet" (1995); Chestnut, oak, ivory lacewood; 72/™" x 24" x 15/™".

Chris Vance, "Staircase" (1998); Wood, paint, glass, lights; 75" x 15" x 50".

Russell Baldon, "Time Capsule" (1995); Wood, steel, mirror; 72" x 36" x 30".

fine furniture," and the author's thesis is that "it is in this lack of possible resolution [between these two traditions] that the significance of art furniture lies."

This seems at first to be an intriguing area for investigation, but I think it proves to be problematic, and ultimately disappointing and unrewarding, for a number of reasons. First is the very term of discussion; what exactly art furniture *is* remains vague throughout the article. Instead, the discussion turns on a number of concepts—function, vocabulary, syntax, surface, and so on—and is illustrated with images of work that have been completely removed from the context in which they were made. This leaves the reader to wonder if these are all supposed to be examples of art furniture, but more importantly, this method of approach creates some missed opportunities. For example, various icons of the Modernist movement, such as Rietveld's "Red/Blue Chair" or the Eames' "LCW Lounge Chair," are scattered through the article, but one gets particular attention, and I would like to use it to better make my point. The piece in question is Achille and Pier Giacomo Castiglioni's "Mezzardo Stool," and it represents seating at its most elemental: a brightly-colored metal tractor seat perched on top of a vertical steel bow, stabilized at its base by a single wooden cross-member. The chair is used to illustrate a discussion of "syntax": the way a "vocabulary" of parts—legs, arms, seat, etc.—can be arranged and organized. A picture of the piece is simply captioned: "In art furniture familiar functions find new forms."

Now, the chair is a remarkable piece, more so because of the circumstances and times in which it was made. To begin with, modernism was not simply a monolith of industrial design, and despite the claims of some of its more strident polemicists, it was fundamentally the product of a level of Abstraction born out of a long intellectual and artistic history, beginning with Plato's ideal forms and continuing through the writings of John Ruskin. It incorporated traditions as old as Japanese design and as recent as the work of Thonet and Charles Rennie Mackintosh. On a social level, it is important to consider that the furniture of Marcel Breuer and Mies van der Rohe was being designed at the same time that Ruhlmann's Art Deco style was reigning in France. Not only was the work avant-garde, there was outright class warfare going on: the modernists' democratic utopian ideals versus Ruhlmann's boast that he only designed for the rich.

The "Mezzardo" was actually designed and fabricated in 1957, in post-war Italy, at a time when some small shops were operating within the context of mass-market production. Furthermore, many of these small companies didn't make a distinction between art and design. This allowed for inventive and provocative



Gord Peteran, "Ark" (2000); Oak, glass, crushed velvet; 72" x 48" x 24".

work, but at the same time, they embraced industry and functionalism. So the "Mezzardo" chair is a perfect example for looking at this dynamic tension. Sadly, we don't get that kind of analysis. It muddles the conversation to refer to this as art furniture; even though it clearly is influenced by Duchamp's "ready-mades," it needs to be understood as a study in "good form," the watchword of post-war European modernist design. There are so many ways to connect the dots that are lost in the discussion, and I think it ultimately points to the dubious value of the whole construct.

A more successful framing of the interplay between art and furniture, concept and aesthetics, is put forth in "The Next Moment in Studio Furniture" by Glenn Adamson, in which he analyzes the work of a group show called "Comfort," mounted by a Canadian collective of makers. The show specifically staked out some "traditional" territory, choosing to focus on one of the fundamental concepts implicit in furniture, but came at it from a number of approaches, some of them quite radical. Among those pieces was Gord Peteran's "Ark," which gained power from the actual experience of it as furniture, as Adamson describes: "You step in, and close the door. Immediately, you feel the pressure of people staring at you. You remember that tube and wonder what it's for. Perhaps you become short of breath. You're feeling the constriction and claustrophobia of total comfort…."

This discussion is enriched by two significant factors. Adamson's concept of the avant-garde is firmly grounded in the studio furniture world and its most basic premises, in which the provocative succeeds precisely because of its contextual references and its relation to traditional notions. Moreover, the actual experience of the furniture informs and invigorates the discussion, making (to my way of thinking) the observations more conceptually rigorous and ultimately more useful.

Glenn Adamson also wrote a catalog essay for the Elvehjem show; surveying studio furniture's recent history, he commented: "The most vexed problems that the Furniture Society has had to confront over its five-year existence are those of self-definition…With maturity comes the increasing burden of nailing down its personality and outlook."

The challenges for studio furniture continue to be creative work, rigorous thinking, and relevance to the everyday world. As the critic Arthur Danto has noted, the artist, the carpenter, and the philosopher have formed, since Plato's time, an "eternal triangle in conceptual politics," and each personage has been at different times elevated to the highest place of importance. At its best, this is a dynamic balance of voices, able both to hold together and encourage growth and change.

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